

Michael Lennon : “Co-inferencing Organizational Symbiosis“

Source: [YouTube](#) Playlist: 4th Applied Active Inference Symposium (2024)

Duration: 59:11 | Uploaded: Unknown Transcript method: auto_caption

okay welcome back from that brief brief break we're here with Michael Lenin and the session is co- inferencing organizational symbiosis so Michael thank you for joining take it away hello yes um I am uh so grateful to be here I would like to um approach today's conversation in um in a conversational style where um I share what led me to active inference and how the discovery of the principles of free energy principle and and active interest changed how I understood as a practitioner and and how that has led both to both personal professional and and organizational um shifts in conversations um one of which will conclude in an invitation to this Community to um experiment with an uh an organizational structure uh designed for um building both the global n knowledge comments um as well as um uh building individual Venture so similar to the way in which uh for example Linux is open source uh and then you have Ventures building off of Linux to do things in the world that that experimenting with such a an organizational model uh for uh the active inference comments uh is some an experiment worth taking on so I I I don't want to let the the final invite get away but but I'm going to backtrack and do this very much in a storytelling fashion so um so um I have some slides but I'm not going to uh spend too much time uh well in fact let me just um skip that just to recap what this um uh what this conversation is about is different ways in which um not just active inference but um science has collided with internal intuition and led to transformational journeys of different kinds and so um and so um I would describe the um you know I I started out as an individual uh as a uh Economist um and um and as a technologist working at um institutions such as the World Bank and IBM and U doing large scale um it implementation projects and um and that work often although there was a lot of um engineering um it was often the human factors that got in the way of success or failure and so um that has been a kind of orienting um how to both be informed by what the the the science and the math provides and uh then build uh how does the biologically based if you will way of sense making um affect or um alter the the the the evolution of of successful project

implementation so um just um a little bit about um about where this uh project um prior to coming to active inference um well I say project my journey um led me through was was um I had a uh I had as I said been trained as a as an economist and um one of the things that economist is a point of view about what it means to grow the culture to grow the society and um primarily denominated in dollars and using um GDP as a way of um of uh tracking whether or not one was impacting the experience of flourishing and um I came across a uh a chart by um by an economist that showed that GDP had tripled in the last 60 years both in the UK and the us and that well-being had not changed at all and this economist who had been in office in the UK at the time when when he left office was kicked out um he went back to Academia and started looking into what do science show moves the needle of well-being and how do we make this socially more contagious and um and I both U loved the idea but I also was um uh shocked by that information because as someone who was trained in a particular lens a particular perspective what I had been trained to do and how to um cause effect and impact was in fact not moving the needle of well-being and so there was this kind of personal and professional crisis um that arose from this uh from this knowledge and um as I say that that led to this this journey of unlearning in some ways and um and in both personal interpersonal and organizational ways of recalibrating the experience of what does it mean to pay attention to thriving and so um that Journey has been very satisfying um not only do I understand how I need to be to experience uh more goosebumps in my life uh I understand uh how I need to be to experience connection and belonging and to co-create with others uh a sense of um of purpose and of meaning that um that I had not had previously and it's uh one of the ways I sometimes uh describe this relationship between the subjective uh internal experience and the scientifically objective let's call it was that I might know how to go to the gym and flex uh my arms to get a workout but by understanding Anatomy I could learn um the bicep had a particular placement in the body a particular Arrangement and I still had to do the workout but I could more effectively and skillfully uh do the work that needed to be done of working out and so similarly the study of the science of well-being um and social uh social uh Sciences of of connection of groups and of um and of um how how for example um one of the surprising findings for me uh in in the realm of Happiness was um a finding by an epidemiologist and um basically he um was studying how do emotions spread and um and he in studying this realized that your happiness um uh was not only more heavily infl uh influenced by the people that you're surrounded by but also by the next degree of separation the people to whom they are connected and even the third degree of separation and so that

these three um Degrees of Separation predicted your happiness more than uh the way that I explained I had been explained what happiness was which was that uh it is an inalienable right like life and Liberty the pursuit of happiness and that it's subject to individual traits of my own that if I just do me the best I can then I'm going to be happier and so all of a sudden there's this disorienting um Insight in that it's not about being my best but it's just as important to inter be my best and so it's like well what the heck does that mean what does it what does it look like to to inhabit one's own experience and one's own skin in in a completely different way and and I know a conversation that uh you and I Daniel once had about um about um the impact of active inference you were describing how you might have been driving on the right hand side of the road your whole life and that all of a sudden you um you uh go to a place where everybody drives on the left and so some intuitions still work exactly as as they used to but others are completely counterintuitive and so this developing the capacity to to go against intuition against the The Familiar is um is part of what sometimes these these these new forms of knowledge there's there's knowledge that that adds to what we know and then there's knowledge that changes how we understand and and happiness first did that for me intuitively at the personal experiential level right it first was like okay I I am playing the game of my own life uh inappropriately um how do I how do I begin to interb my best instead of be my best and this is where um uh some subsequent work in working personally and then with groups and and organizationally led to um paying attention to what was happening in in a different way and uh so I uh as I say this this um crisis led to a very fruitful um Learning Journey and um and uh excuse me I um I got distracted um some of this led to writing different ways of describing how to do work and so for example one of the spaces that I've been working in was in U government Consulting and in government Consulting top down um uh uh is often the way to direct the effectiveness of the organization um you come up with the right strategy you figure out all the components and you then execute on the plan and uh and so in a sense uh if there are two forms of of uh probabilistic prediction a basian being one at the heart of of active inference and another one being fisher fisher is one that that says it knows where you need to go and the way that you relate to to surprises and to mistakes and errors is you correct back to what you felt your original plan was whereas basian probabilism probability obviously um can have similar results but also can update instead of reacting to surprise as something to be fixed it can sometimes be something to be adapted to and uh it changes the way that uh manage you manage um the the uh emergence of differing information from what you originally predicted and so so in the same way that I described that happiness uh had a disorienting effect on how

to practice it active inference has a similar um disorienting effect about how to co-regulate um how to supervise the um the evolution of of differences between what you expect and what you what you get and um one way in which I I describe this uh to to folks is it changes your understanding or changed my understanding of how cause and effect works that um you know as as as I arrived to um to um active inference there were there were a couple of intuitions about uh how the world operated that active inference helped um evolve the first was that instead of instead of the world being composed of objects um that were fixed and stable that um that the mathematics of how to explain things was much more of a dynamic verb and so to look at the world as being not nouns but verbs and and and a way that I describe this for myself when talking to people about it is that instead of seeing myself as a self a noun that I'm a a be a being and so um that pain paying attention to the continuous verbing and the relating uh to to to others is is a is a different um uh a different game and so um the interesting thing about active inference was that there was a mathematics for describing this that um that related the internal States and the external States um through uh mathematics of information that the way in which um the the way in which um uh science Works um is is is familiar and intuitive to to to many of us um Let me let me let me rephrase this in a different way that you know when I say the inside and the outside are informationally connected um that that um that the outside is all the information all the stimulus of the world and that the inside creates a map of that world and that the mathematics of creating that map not only um uh reduce the world and is a mathematically um efficient way of describing how to make the how to get the most signal for for all the information that's being received but that it also um it it also um enables like I was describing earlier with the understanding of the bicep a more accurate way of sensing the world of um orienting to the world and um and of responding to the world um I I should have uh shared my my slides instead of trying to talk through them but I'm going to take a a pause and ask any any questions or shall I proceed yeah uh I'll ask one question and then looking forward to slides dsk wrote there has been a lot of talk around GDP not being a good enough metric of national development has your research informed you on a better metric if so does it have a working name so yes and it's a different um answer than a single metric so the metric a single metric was one of the problems and the fact that it was denominating currency was one of the problems so one of the things that uh has shifted um some of the work of uh the UN of of really a group led by Bill Bowie and Ralph thurm on um on what are called contextual indicators are that um are that instead of an indicator being um GDP is both currency and it's um it's set to a single the denominator and the nominator of the indicator are both set in in the

same thing so um let me describe this in a in a different way um there has been a diversification of what are the things to pay attention to so not only um dollars but also subjective experience of well-being for example better predicts the outcome of Elections than does Financial income and so um the idea that dollars are are predictive accurately predictive of um of outcomes has been often relied upon and turns out to be U maladapted right and so that's um whether whether you're talking about biological phenomenon whether you're talking about social phenomena there's a whole range of extra indicators that are now seen as um not a single one but but better visibility into these different nested levels of of Life the second what I would call breakthrough type of indicator Beyond GDP that I was describing denominator and uh not numerator is that um most organizational reporting for example is is um for example example um Starbucks might say we are using 10,000 gallons less of water than we did last year so we are improving um our consumption and the way that we are related to um The Watershed that we might be related to and and all that um reporting is if you will individual Centric and when you Center your just like as as with happiness you know where if you're just looking at the at the individual you're missing an important part of the picture when when measuring your relationship to resources to Commons to um natural Commons and social Commons um if you if you put your um uh individual Behavior within the context of the collective so let's say Starbucks says uh we used 10,000 gallons last year out of the total Watershed then you can begin to draw comparisons about how everybody is using the Watershed as a whole and how the percentage the percentage behavior of of usage of the water has shifted that can be compared from one to the next to the next so if you will you're putting these indicators in a in a similar language in a similar uh they're speaking in a in a similar base than um than when they are um reported individually and so you know when when looking at at well-being it's it's important not only to to add additional things Beyond money but it's also important that these indicators be um set to the same um denominator or or you wind up not having the visibility that you need and there's a huge cat fight about this because uh there have been a whole series of um of Privileges and a whole series of um um social practices that are grounded in the way in which um uh individual corporations are um are structured and so this this kind of points to a different kind of natural meeme that I wanted to bring up that might be of of Interest so so um we talked about how it with happiness um you know we we're doing it individually and that we're missing the relational um when you look at uh cells that um are part of an organism if they are traumatized uh they become more individualistic they become uh they consume more they reproduce more and they grow into what we call a cancer because

their if you will relationality is traumatized and they become more and more selfish and so there's there's both a huge importance of paying attention attention to relationality at the level of the cell at the level of the individual human and some would say at the level of clusters of humans such as organizations and that with cancer part of the um new form of treatment has been to call the cells informationally back into relation so instead of punitive burning those cells and killing them it's to remind them of their relatedness to restore them from a traumatized State back into relationship with other cells and they begin to behave again in better relation to the body around them and so that metaphor speaks to the importance of how do we call each other back into relation if the language of individualism is permeating both our individual Behavior and the language of Corporations is equally um traumatized because originally when when uh corporations were first formed in the 1600s in uh in the Netherlands they were really people coming together to venture and do together what they could not do alone so trading with um the Far East was was something that no individual uh Capital uh no individual business owner could could afford to venture but by pulling their funds they were able to do and they were able to become a great trading power globally this model of groups behaving as groups so a different cluster of um of uh of existence groups um and then behaving um pro-socially with each other is what grew the next level of um economic performance and economic um um Effectiveness um however over time some would say that organizations have become traumatized and have become disconnected both from the places where they originated as well as from all the stakeholders that they were serving and so for example here in the US when when the Supreme Court last century two centuries ago now almost decided that financially Financial stakeholders were the foremost important um stakeholders in corporations they distorted the relationality of of Corporations and so it has become a kind of cancer that that has become extractivist both upon the its its employees upon the the the ecosystems in which it inhabits by architecture so there are plenty of people that will tell you in in an organization we want to be more attentive to these um other considerations Beyond Finance but but we don't even have permission because the agreements of the corporation have evolved from mutualism to um to selfishness if you will to more consumerism more productivity more Surplus and those all have a place they're they're they're important but they've become like like the cells in the body that become cancerous they've become overly um overly uh they become individually uh oriented alone and and not sufficiently skillful at at mutualism and so this all comes back to a new basis for equipping organizations to pay attention to how they're interrelating within between and to things beyond

their current purview and it is as much of a disorienting and challenging um uh um uh bit of information as I was just as I was sharing the idea of learning how to be more skillful at happiness was to me personally you know it's like oh I have to pay more attention to you to for for us to be happier or to be the third degree of separation as I was describing earlier means that not only the people to whom I'm directly connected but that really that it's my dumb number the dumb number being presumably the 150 to the 250 people that you have meaningful relationships in your life the dumb cubed so it's beyond your direct sensory observation and it's like how do you co- Haron eyesee across groups how do you sing to use a different kind of language songs in common to which you're Co coordinated and um and these are some of the things that um active inference provides a mathematics for how this works you know that is fascinating of how the synchronization of the individual to the group and the nesting and and how the signaling happens across the nested groups and so it's it's um it's fascinating the mathematics can be daunting but the promise of it and the ability to do these things more skillfully and reliably is just it gives me goosebumps it gives me goosebumps and this is part of um why I'm trying to tell this somewhat ineffectively I would say today in a story Manner and through experience so that people can pull on the intuitions that they have the memories that they have and say I dare to tackle this uncertainty building upon these intuitions and feelings that I have and Co experimenting with others forward and so this is at the heart of what the uh what the original invitation that I mentioned was about was you know that instead of the classic hierarchical um corporation that um that has as part of its founding documents when you when you plant a seed and you use the template that says we are we are organizing according to these rules even if you want to change it's it's like it's a lot harder to change the Constitution than it is some minor policy in a back office in a you know in your in your um you know in some app that you might be uh writing the code for you know and and similarly it's important to to incubate um uh organisms that have the relationality the mutualism and the holistic perspective codified into and and the intering codified into how they behave individually inter intercluster and then in relation to the comments that they might serve and so before I take a turn into the case for um the experiment that I was hoping to invite people to uh do together any any any more questions popping up sure I can ask some short questions then slides and invitation okay lightning round okay Arun asked isn't there a cyclic dependency of economic factors and happiness for example High inflation made everyone sad over 2024 so there there is um uh there are um time lag factors uh that impact um uh when we how the economy operates and how individuals operate and these are not necessarily in sync

one of the things that um that uh I found from the um from the science of Happiness was um more effective ways to carry the suffering and so um some have that this change that just happened politically for example um is a bad thing of often when things break open there are whole new Realms of possibility to to be had and so um happiness is not just about having all positive emotions it's about taking well-being is the word actually I should be using is about absorbing all of the signal that the universe is is giving all that's coming in and then optimizing within that and so um the breaking down can also be a breaking open for what there is to to uh become and so that is not to say that there is a lack of struggle or pain or friction one of the great intuitions for me um that that arose from from studying people explaining active inference was um how things emerge and the person explaining it was using water and uh they they were describing still water as being the way in which current conventions of how things got done and how people calculated so if you're if you're in Still Water if you're in a lake and you're trying to get across um the way you Rod your boat or the way you swim is all set by the conditions of the water in um in flowing water um even though those that same water has the same physical properties uh as Still Water it weighs the same no matter whether it's moving or not um when when the friction of the water over rocks um creates new dynamics that emerge it creates whirlpools right and that those structures um that persist um you know the creation of order out of disorder um allow for the emergence of also other meta patterns that are again described by informational mathematics rather than the physics of the water itself and and this is this is again trying to get it what is so hard to Intuit it's like oh these the whether whe it's a single Whirlpool coming into existing or whirlpools into whirlpooling into into greater movements that um that these frictions are also creative and so to really um be willing to settle into the into the dis into the what you were calling the cyclical disconnect in a symmetry um as as something that is a signal also that can be driving learning driving better calibration um can be driving um new learning uh because at the heart of all of active inference is a mathematics of continuous learning um yes I I love that and just blows like water with our previous sessions okay next question and then back into the flow we go social Design Studio wrote so curious about the transition away from from individualistic and mechanical into Collective and organic where is the most levered locality to start well that's a a great question and um here's um a way in which I would answer this in the in the world of project evaluation so there's a point of view um in the world of systems thinking there's a certain order of what to um what of the you know Donella Meadows is well known for for uh the way in which she created this categorization of ways to intervene in a system and um uh in the world of

evaluating um projects and programs complex projects and program over time uh there's been some some meta studies done about what are the things that best predict uh that if if the supervision is done uh attending to certain factors what are the things that seem to produce effective and positive results because we're talking about complexity you could pick a thousand things but in in this research they identified three things and I'll add two the three things that they said you know when people look at the following things they they tend to not only manage what they thought they were looking for but also what emerges in other words managing the surprise and the unexpected more effectively and the three things were looking at the inter relationality surprise surprise right we're talking paying attention to the interbeing and the interbeing across not just the individual or whatever whatever our our individual unit of focus was originally but but who are seeing the system more holistically second um multiperspectivity um and the way that I in my the way I uh describe this for my myself is um I say looking within looking between and looking beyond having one or more um disciplines and perspectives and ways of knowing about uh those those lenses of of attention on what is happening um uh if we look to if we look within we often become a better compass for our own lives um uh if we um if we look between we often develop and harness the intelligence uh that collectively and the Insight that we have and when we look Beyond we often detect uh patterns that are beyond our Collective purview that might uh um break open and um enable us to to transform in in powerful ways so again to return to that second Point multiperspectivity um and I suggest with those three uh lenses which is what I call the me to we to all you know um and it's it's kind of the label that I'm putting on on this invitation I'm going to bring up later um is um is a is a good starting point is it enough no but it's a great starting point and then thirdly and here's where it gets messy and is the non-answer to your original question is um scope definition um because the moment you pick what are the boundaries what is my mark of blanket you know what what what is the what are the boundaries of the map that I'm going to use as my lens you begin to abstract everything else into what fits in that lens so so if you say we're going to have this conversation in English the way that we everything we describe will be denominated mostly in nouns instead of in verbs and with Concepts that exist in English but don't exist in other languages and so um the attending to what are the boundaries that we will use to focus is is a gigantic mechanism for seeing um how you're holding your attention and so again it's not a fixed answer but it's a way of attending to perception again repeating relationships diversity of perspectives and scope definition uh the other two that I like to add in that um were not part of that research so that

research by the way was um a 100 Years of developmental evaluation um you know hundreds of studies and and so it's very robust and you can you can go to the bank that that's a good place to start building your dashboard or not the dashboard your conversations about the dashboard um the other two that I would add and and these in part come from active inference and from other systemic view places and Views is looking at patterns how are we you know what are we clustering and looking at flows you know um what what are the core flows are we looking at energy if we're looking at biological systems are we looking at the water flows you know life organizes around water um so do do we understand what are the core flows of information of energy whatever uh in the system that we are observing that that that gives us a a key insight into the way in which causality unfolds um and causality uh organizes itself around and that it's not the mechanistic you know geometry that we we may have intuited in uh for for the longest time but that by looking at Source by looking at flow we we develop a better compass for for the world thank you it's it's awesome and the live chat is super lit you'll see it after um in the last 20 minutes do you want to share your slides and open the invitation letter yes so uh let me um switch here to share um share are you seeing my screen okay uh me so um the invitation uh was um was to test a new way of organizing and a fair share Commons is a kind of um a mutualistic co-op that um first originated in the UK and has been endorsed by the financial I I I should have read it down here because I can't remember like the finance trust accounting Board of of the UK it's spread through many countries of the Commonwealth of the last uh 15 20 years and it's primarily an adapted form of organizational structure that is intended to both cultivate the practice of mutualism within the group so it's kind of like a co-op um in that everybody has power uh to to participate it's self-governing um and that it attends to the relationality of the founders the workers and uh and external whether they're investors or they they self-organize it's really uh there is a a pattern language about forming co-ops and one can use that pattern language to to um to to form these Commons and that these whether they are to create Ventures um or to create um full businesses that the pattern language is useful for that effect um and so as I described earlier a kind of um you know it's it's intended to grow the commons but also to support the application of those Commons and build the organizational traits uh for successful Ventures and what I am uh hoping to find allies uh around um oops let me um so it um the these are again suggested and there are many ways to to go about it but um you know there there's certain core agreements that differ from if you will the extractivism and the foundation is uh relationality um which drives mutualism symbiosis um and uh the the invitation um is to um is to constitute one in service of the active

inference uh Community for growing both the commons and the capacity to um to prototype and devel both the the experience of mutualism but also projects and that uh there' be two starting experiments um the first around prototyping uh agents for accelerating access to money so often um folks incubating a new project are looking to find funding for that project um find uh funding for what that project might serve and often there are people willing to fund those projects and the idea of wrri up what are the sources of different funding what are the sources of what what are the needs that they have that they're looking to fund how do I um discover and engage that um funding is an important agent that can be used in common after common after common and so possibly developing a um an agent or uh there are plenty of methods but but agen toying if you will uh that component as one of the key flows you know that in business the flow of money is is an important element to to an activate and and that the second is about um finding um resources of a different kind competence and complementarity and um what are the what are the components often for example a u uh the active inference Community has a wide diversity of competencies um the but but it is highly highly Tech techical and so to engage with people who who um have complimentary SK skills um uh and and um and to support the accelerated discovery of allies not only based on competencies but also on um uh other holistic considerations is um is the attending to the flow of mutualism um and so those those three um actions is kind of a starting point is um is something that I would like to um I'm I'm already in action on the uh with with other groups um and a variety of groups on the constituting the legal structure of a of a fair sharing commment um and I would like to enroll um the active entrance Community to become an ally with with kind of other competencies and other types of mutualistic eco-minded socially minded groups to grow grow um the capacity for mutualism and it's early stage I literally um this this is germinating you could say and really would like to um would like to find allies who who knowing that we don't have all the answers but that we're willing to grow not just the methods but the relational soil um is um is what this is really about so um yeah awesome Stu there awesome exciting I can ask some questions from live chat and we can explore just a little bit of a shall I leave this on the screen or keep going sure you can leave it up I'll ask there's a lot of great comments I'll just start with the direct question so people can add more in this last 15 minutes okay social Design Studio wrote does the commons use emergent hierarchy so as to accommodate contextual expertise and thus relational power so um great question and um there are several definitions of Commons um but I'm going to go with elen orstrom she won the Nobel Prize for it and um and she she basically defined it as it's whatever Mark of blanket people choose and then self-

organize around so so um there are many variations and um and in order she she identified eight principles for common to not just be a nice idea but to be able to persist sustainably right um just to do a little sidebar she she was trying to make a business the reason she won the Nobel Prize is because in the profession um everybody was explaining most of the economy's activities as either being driven through hierarchies or through marketplaces the Dynamics of those two Collective groups and she said there's a Third Kind of group a common and it has the following properties and um the socially mutualistic uh side of the world was just in love with her and this is why she won the Nobel Prize because she developed not only a body of Science and a series of eight principles that predictably describe those that succeed these eight include you know a sense of a boundaries that they have in common and whether they decide to self-organize around a fishery whether they decide to organize around um a data comment around uh a knowledge comment that is up for the group to to decide and then um the the way in which they co-regulate um she did there there were many variations but but basically there was a um there had to be agreements on where to place shared attention and as people diverged from the Norms that there were ways to call them back into relationship ship and to have escalating um consequences if people deviated um now all of that sounds lovely but um but that was not enough either there had to be the ability to enforce one's boundaries not only internally but externally and so I'll give you an example um I I uh have some First Nation friends with whom I've been meeting every Friday for years to work on decolonizing our minds and they have a point of view about a piece of land that um that is their Garden of Eden and sacred and how it should be used or not be used and they use all these principles but they cannot enforce their agreements on other people and so they really what they have is a wish list I mean I know that's kind of rude and they'll be very pissed to hear me say this but without the capacity to enforce your your boundaries you um you don't have a Commons and so um this idea of uh how enforcement happens and whether that is done in a hierarchical manner or whether that's done by self-organizing you know like when when uh in Valencia recently there was a a a gigantic flash flood you know the government um did a very poor job for the first week and the response was is done by self-organizing ant behavior of neighbors helping neighbors coming in doing whatever they and that happens in crisis after crisis after crisis and um and so there is a a capacity to self-organize if you will and get things done um often what a government structure can do is help prioritize bring order to the what are the most pressing needs how to discern what will make the biggest difference collectively and so there is a value to having a coordinating role but um but uh you know how that emerges or evolves or unfolds

is um can either be by by cultural precedent of what the rules are or it can emerge through and from the group so um so that's my long comment about Commons and and commoning and how to be in relationship to the common awesome I I'll read a comment from Scott even before you mentioned asrom Scott had written Commons Elanor Ostrom is a co-management regime framing nicely consistent with active inference in human organizational contexts C Scott Shackleford at all at you of Indiana for Awesomes Commons programs Commons analyses have historically been focused on quote asset based Commons this nicely anticipates common co-management Beyond Asset Management I.E risk management skills coordination Etc yep I I should have made the point that um one of the things that Commons do that uh that the marketplaces and the institutions have not been able to do is for example it is financially rational to fish to Extinction to deplete the forest because the price just keeps on going up so so so um the logic of markets is insufficient for for sustainability and this is why organizations that don't have a logic of of of that friction of of um of considering other factors other than profit maximization will inevitably um deplete the resource um and so what she created with this um case for Commons was that there were sustainable organizations and that these existed both in indigenous you know in in original people cultures they exist uh throughout developed economies they exist in a variety of places and are unrecognized and what what you're hearing this in this invitation is like let's let's let's choose commoning even though it's unfamiliar even though it's different it's actually much more widespread than we ever have experience you know it's it's like believing that there might be something other than McDonald's you see McDonald's everywhere so you think I have to eat burgers but there are other ways to eat than McDonald's and not trying to pick a fight with uh fast food but how are we going to carry this forward into 2025 and Beyond yes so um so the invitation to join um a conversation is is the beginning one one of the Allies is um that is both co-incubating other Commons and that I wanted to use for if there's energy here is um a a group called uh evolute 6 uh based in Germany and and uh South Africa and UK uh it's a small firm dedicated to incubating uh and helping Commons type organizations grow um it's kind of the we uh um and and so uh trying to both invite the interested to begin join the conversation sharpen uh a vision and an understanding of what it is that we think we can be in action on uh what is it that how that active inference can be applied to particular problems the search for funding there might be a better way I had to I had to scramble to get something plausible but if as we have conversations we might very well identify much more um important points of intervention with the question that somebody body else was asking earlier we might decide that there are

certain flows and certain dynamics that are in fact a great a better starting point than what I imagine right now but uh the invitation is come let's convene and do this in a systematic way and both be transformed individually interpersonally and ripple out into the world awesome okay few more questions while we're still here Frasier wrote I'm not sure what this language of trauma means I'd like to hear this elaborated yes excellent sorry um I forgot to explain that so um uh lately in Psychology and in organizational psychology uh there has become a modified use of the word trauma and um and what it refers to is the equivalent of memory in in computation so you can have a traumatic event and be traumatized by it and then the trauma as as I'm using it is the memory the scar that's left either in you or the um if it's it's a if it's a collective trauma that has a different um property I'll describe it in a moment but but when I say it's the memory the scar is what remains in you and how you carry that whether you heal fully or whether it becomes a a debilitating d Dynamic is is when the word trauma can be used to describe it Collective trauma is um and this is an important distinction because sometimes the same language can create confusion um uh when I'm acting as an individual cognitive system I am all the trauma happens within my body so I feel something I fix something or I have a story about something happening to me all of that is personal trauma if I'm part of a hive the the um hiving is happening in the signals that we are sending back and forth to each other and so um the uh the this the the language of how we signal and the meaning of what that means is what can become traumatized and let me give you a simple little example uh and and those are called trauma agreements ways in which you agree to carry the the significance the pain the feeling about the situation that you're looking at so so my father took me fishing when I was 8 years old for the first time and we caught a fish with fish and Hook and the fish was flapping and resisting you know and I was kind of shocked I'm like oh my God that fish is suffering my father's like no no no no no you just grab you know whack them on the head knock them out and they don't feel pain and in that moment I entered into a trauma agreement a different understanding of how to be with what I was observing and as a group we would talk about the our reality assuming that shared trauma agreement that shared way of of understanding that same kind of dynamic whether it is how what it means to be a certain gender what it means to be an organization that is um beneficial to the world is it because it makes a profit is it because it makes a contribution there's a whole series of assumed agreements that that it's like oh we need to surface them that they're not the truth they are an agreement into which we stepped and we're now willing to re-evaluate and this is both the the the gateway to disorientation but also transformative adaptation um because it changes what

has been uh a habitual way when when when I started considering that maybe animals are still an omnivore but when I started considering um that maybe animals had feelings I had to start thinking differently about what had been my AR eating patterns and so this is a language for surfacing um anti- symbiotic ways of being that we are now developing a pattern and a way of recognizing them and renegotiating them awesome great answer last question musicm minded wrote how does Michael see the future of businesses or more simply do you have Exemplar businesses that are commons type in your view yes there's a whole range of Commons businesses and and and so even though we're talking here about incubating a new one in a sense um I I believe that the the important work is about what I was describing about treating cancer calling back into relation and so um some of us and this you know if there's interest in this I've been working with with global standard setting groups about how to measure monitor well-being and then how to so there's the sensing it and then there's the what do I how do we digest it you and this was another benef another you know benefit from from active inference was the way of framing the cognitive process not just think but sensing integrating predicting responding adapting and and really helping organizations think about in that cognitive flow in that Collective cognitive flow how to recalibrate them their their attention so that they see more of the world with with a denominate a planetary denominator rather than an organizational denominator and how do they then more skillfully interrelate with the different factors in which they're they're they're engaging perfect thank you Michael great presentation a lot of people appreciated it in the chat so see you next time thank you thank you e for